



Lighting makes all the difference

4.2 Creating Lights

The various types of lighting can be accessed by choosing Create > Lights or by selecting the light icon in the Create panel. 3ds Max has two main categories of lights: standard and photometric. The types of lights you select will depend on the application and type of renderer you select. Standard lights are used with 3ds Max's scanline renderer and with the Mental Ray renderer. They are the choice for animation and most other applications. Photometric lights are used with the scanline renderer's radiosity feature to create accurate lighting for architectural applications.

Light Parameters

Standard lights have the same parameter rollouts used to create and define the character of the light. Standard lights are used for most applications and can create a wide range of lighting, from highly realistic to highly stylized. Architectural applications need highly accurate lighting that simulates the real world. Photometric lighting is perfect for creating these types of images.

There are options to set the type of light, turn it on/off, and create a target for aiming the light. Other options include options to set the type of shadow as well as options to turn shadows on or off. There is also a value that multiplies the intensity of the light. This value can be negative to remove light from the scene. Values are used to attenuate the light close to the source. The Exclude button brings up a dialog box that allows the light to illuminate only specific objects in the scene.

Types of Lights

Different parts of the scene may need different types of lights. Some parts of